

ANNA NAGAR

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Clicks and flicks

R. RAGU

S. Singarayer pursues two professions which share an essential feature, both rely on sharp timing; and in almost every other respect, they are galaxies apart. He has become a past master at switching between these diverse skillsets, one requiring him to click the camera button, and the other flick the Silambam stick.

A freelance events photographer, Singarayer had settled into a comfort zone, the photography assignments and payments steady and regular enough for him to want to break out of it and explore new ground. But here he is, teaching two batches of Silambam enthusiasts, one class being conducted in Villivakkam and the other at RBI Quarters in Kilpauk. And so, what got 49-year-old Singarayer here?

Before that question is answered, a quick bio of a younger Singarayer.

He entered the world letting out a shrill cry in Thiruvavur, where he grew up, along the way getting introduced to Silambam at school. He would go on to earn a B.Com degree at an arts college in Kumbakonam, and also qualify in printing technology, a course that helped him develop design skills. Career aspirations brought him to Chennai in 2000, and photography was nowhere in sight in those early years, but computers were. He had worked as a systems services technician at Ritchie Street off Mount Road for around three years when his primary calling came into sharp focus. A career in photography began, one that continues to this day.

A photographer revisits a childhood passion which has led him to the avocation of teaching Silambam to enthusiasts. Currently, he runs two batches, one in Villivakkam and the other in Kilpauk

He worked at the Konica outlet at Wallajah Road in Chepauk for 15 years, primarily working with photography software, framing pictures, restoring old photos and creating albums. And then he decided to strike out on his own, camera in hand: a long run as events photographer began.

Answering the question, he managed to circle back to his childhood passion, Silambam, through his daughter S.S. Sharoni. While ac-

companying Sharoni to Silambam classes, Singarayer would watch the training sessions from the sidelines. Gradually, he began brushing up on his old skills wielding the Silambam staff.

K. Shankar (aged 53), the Silambam master coaching Sharoni became coach to Singarayer too. An MTC bus driver having found a space to practise Silambam in his leisure time, Shankar was at the same wavelength as Singarayer.



Silambam masters S. Singarayer and K. Shankar with students at Villivakkam. PHOTOS. RAGU

Learn folk arts

Government College Of Fine Arts in Egmore offers four courses in folk arts, silambam being one. These are not regular programmes but conducted during the weekend and come under Folk Art Centre, an initiative being promoted by the government at select colleges in the state.

Each college offers some folk art examples being thappattam, paraattam and karagattam, largely based on the kind of enquiries they get. According to the principal, there is no age criteria to enrol in these programmes and the idea is to give people an opportunity to pursue hobbies with a cultural underpinning.

For details, call 044 - 25610878

Having noticed Singarayer's command over the Silambam staff, he encouraged him to pursue the martial art seriously.

The encouragement went further. Impressed by Singarayer's handling of Silambam techniques, the master eventually entrusted him with a batch of students of his own.

For the last three years, Singarayer has been conducting Silambam classes regularly. Assisting him in training sessions is Sharoni herself, now 14 years old and studying in Class IX. She has already won several medals at district-level competitions.

Singarayer offers Silambam coaching at a nominal fee of ₹500 per month; and to those who cannot afford that, he offers it free.

Determined to deepen his understanding of the martial art, Singarayer recently completed a one-year certification course in Silambam offered by the Tamil Nadu Government's Department of Art and Culture at the Government College of Fine Arts in Egmore.

For details, call Rajammal Silambam Boxing Sports Academy at 9841887183

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Bougainvillea Park visitors await its reopening

The curtains will go up in a fortnight,
say GCC officials



Bougainvillea Park in Anna Nagar East.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

L KANTHIMATHHI

Regulars at Bougainvillea Park located at Sixth Avenue in Anna Nagar East, want the gates of the facility swung open at the earliest.

The park is undergoing renovation since November 2025, carried out by Greater Chennai Corporation at a cost of ₹2.93 crore.

According to GCC officials of Zone 8, the work is nearing completion and the plan is to reopen it in a fortnight.

A new landscape will be welcoming the visitors. Sprawling lawns, gaze-



bos, new walkways, a book reading pavilion, an indoor Yoga centre, and new equipment in children's play area and outdoor gym are some of the features of the facelift project.

The existing fountain has been given a fresh coat of paint.

The park is marked by decades-old-trees; and they have been joined by saplings.

The new compound wall combines a brick-and-mortar structure with picket style metal grills.

The decades-old, big metal gate has received a sleek facade.

It is now a brick-and-mortar, pure white structure built in the post-and-lintel style. Flanked by a Terracotta Jali work and a brick wall, the entrance stands out.

Residents are impressed with the park's new look. A suggestion from residents is that food items should not be allowed inside the park.



A TEACHER'S LEGACY: FROM CLASSROOMS TO CANOPIES

Today, as she retires from service, biology teacher V. Kalaiselvi counts among her achievements a sense of stewardship towards nature particularly trees she instilled in her students. **P3**



EQUIPPED FOR OFFICE, EMPOWERED FOR LIFE

The one-year diploma programme offered by Muttukadu-based NIEPMD in association with Bharathidasan University strikes a commendable balance between technical and soft skills. **P4**

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KNOW YOUR NEIGHBOUR

Making the
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60

Meet coach and counsellor Ebenezer Joseph who recently won three gold medals in the 60+ category at the Commonwealth Chess Championships

K. KEERTHIVASAN

At 60, Ebenezer Joseph is a bundle of energy. He coaches children, trains teachers, competes in tournaments and also serves as counsellor for educational institutions, strongly advocating the inclusion of chess in school curricula.

Recently, the Anna Nagar resident, who works as an Audit Su-

pervisor in the Indian Audit & Accounts Department (IA & AD) at the Finance and Audit Office in Egmore, made headlines after winning three gold medals in the classical, rapid and blitz events in the 60+ category at the Commonwealth Chess Championships held in Kalutara, Sri Lanka.

Ebenezer was thrilled with the achievement, especially since he had only hoped to return with at least a bronze medal. "I expected to win one bronze medal, but to win three gold medals was unbelievable. Though I won in the 60+ category,



Ebenezer Joseph (second from left) felicitated by Aadhav Arjuna, MLA, Villivakkam and other dignitaries

ry, I played in the Open section alongside top young Grandmasters such as P. Iniyar and S. Rohith Krishna, besides FIDE Master Sakline Mostafa Sajid, Candidate Master S. Sivathanujan and Woman Candidate Master Ananya Raman. It felt great," he said.

Speaking about the demands of competing in three formats, which often meant spending long hours at the board, Ebenezer said the tournament was physically and mentally exhausting. "The pressure was immense because on certain days we had to play as many as

eight rounds. My matches started at 4 p.m. and finished at 8 p.m., so much so that on the last day I hardly knew what was happening on the board!" he said with a smile.

Having spent more than 34 years with the Indian Audit & Accounts Department, Ebenezer felt the process of obtaining a No Objection Certificate (NOC) from employers to participate in international tournaments should be simplified. "When a player is representing the country, the process of getting an NOC from the employer to take part in an international

event should be made easier," he said.

Ebenezer continues to balance his professional commitments with his passion for chess and social service. "I will continue playing, continue trying to help more sportspeople get recruited into Government offices and continue working with tribal communities," said the 60-year-old, who is also a Senior Lead Instructor for FIDE Chess in Education Commission and is set to retire from IA & AD in November this year.



The post office on SIDCO Nagar First Main Road in Villivakkam.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Parking challenges near
Villivakkam post office’

LILIYAN SWARNA KALAI

Customers to Villivakkam post office on SIDCO Nagar First Main Road find it difficult to park their vehicles near the facility. The section of the road along the post office is occupied by an autorickshaw stand. Auto drivers prevent parking of other vehicles here. Further, metal barricades are placed in front of the post

office to prevent parking of other vehicles. But they don't seem to be placed by the Greater Chennai Corporation Traffic Police.

This post office offers various services and therefore witnesses a good number of customers. But vehicular parking is an issue here. The authorities concerned are requested to look into this issue.

Liliyan Swarna Kalai is a resident of Villivakkam

‘Electricity cable
poses a risk’

The image, taken on May 30, 2026, shows a live electric cable protruding on Medawakkam Tank Road in Kilpauk. The exact spot is opposite Tamil Nadu Institute of Mental Health & Neurosciences. This is very dangerous. TANGEDCO officials should address this issue at the earliest.

D. Radhakrishnan is a resident of Kilpauk

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‘New safety system in metro trains: A welcome move’

S. SANKARANARAYANAN



PHOTO USED FOR REPRESENTATIONAL PURPOSE ONLY.

In addition to the existing "obstacle detection system," a safety feature in the automatic sliding saloon doors of metro trains which are in operation (Phase One), Chennai Metro Rail Limited has now come up with "anti-drag feature," another new safety measure again incorporated in the automatic sliding saloon doors. The new feature was introduced two weeks ago.

Factoring in the Indian way of clothing, especially that of women who wear lengthy clothes such as dupattas, shawls, and saris that are likely to get trapped in the automatic sliding doors, CMRL has introduced this feature.

This is a welcome move. Because the metro trains witness heavy rush during peak hours forcing passengers to lean on the doors. Hence, such a feature is essential.

S.Sankaranarayanan is a resident of Anna Nagar

A teacher's legacy: from classrooms to canopies

Today, as she retires from service, biology teacher V. Kalaiselvi counts among her achievements a sense of stewardship towards nature particularly trees she instilled in her students. Here is a living testament to this attitude: robust trees at a neighbourhood in Maduravoyal that she helped plant 15 years ago directing a group of NSS volunteers from The Hindu Theological Higher Secondary School in Sowcarpet

School for 18 years, and in the last two years, at WPA Soundarapandian Higher Secondary School in Ayanavaran on compulsory deployment). As she bows out of service, one believes, the saplings she helped plant, and which are now strapping big trees, at Chokkanathan Nagar in Maduravoyal will sway in appreciation.

What was an effort lasting days by NSS student volunteers from this school in Sowcarpet has translated into a gain that continues across years for residents, making summers more bearable and the locality more environmentally sustainable. D. Narasimhan, secretary of the RWA at Chokkanathan Nagar, points out that a majority of trees from that initiative are Indian beech tree (*Pongamia pinnata*).

“The main aim was to increase the oxygen supply and educate the future generation about the importance of nature and the need to protect it,” says Kalaiselvi, thrilled at the opportunity to recall and reconstruct the exercise from the ground up.

Funding and logistics demanded meticulous planning, notes Kalaiselvi, adding hands stretched out with generosity, and some of those belonged to the residents. A good amount went out from Kalaiselvi's purse.

From the word go, the exercise had one component going for it: collective community effort. Residents of the locality reportedly welcomed the students wholeheartedly and contributed to the initiative in various ways which included arranging food and ensuring an interactive and pleasant experience for the students. The collective contribution transformed the planting initiative into a source of inspiration. Kalaiselvi also acknowledges the contribution of then deputy mayor P. Benjamin, whose support helped the campaign handsomely.

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

V. Selvaraj, a resident of Chokkanathan Nagar in Maduravoyal and vice president of the enclave's residents welfare association, has a plea for Greater Chennai Corporation: “trim the trees, please!”. There is a sense of urgency in that polite but firm imperative and also an unstated pride. He has seen those trees in their “toddler” years, as defenceless saplings. Those days are only 15 years into the past, when a tree-planting campaign swept across Chokkanathan Nagar. It was powered by around 30 NSS students from The Hindu Theological Higher Secondary School in Sowcarpet under the guidance of the school's NSS officer V. Kalaiselvi and the headmastership of V. Selvaraj.

Planted by tender hands, the initiative has photosynthesised into a powerful statement about community service. And the reason to revisit this initiative now? May 31 marks Kalaiselvi's day of retirement. (She served as biology teacher at The Hindu Theological Higher Secondary



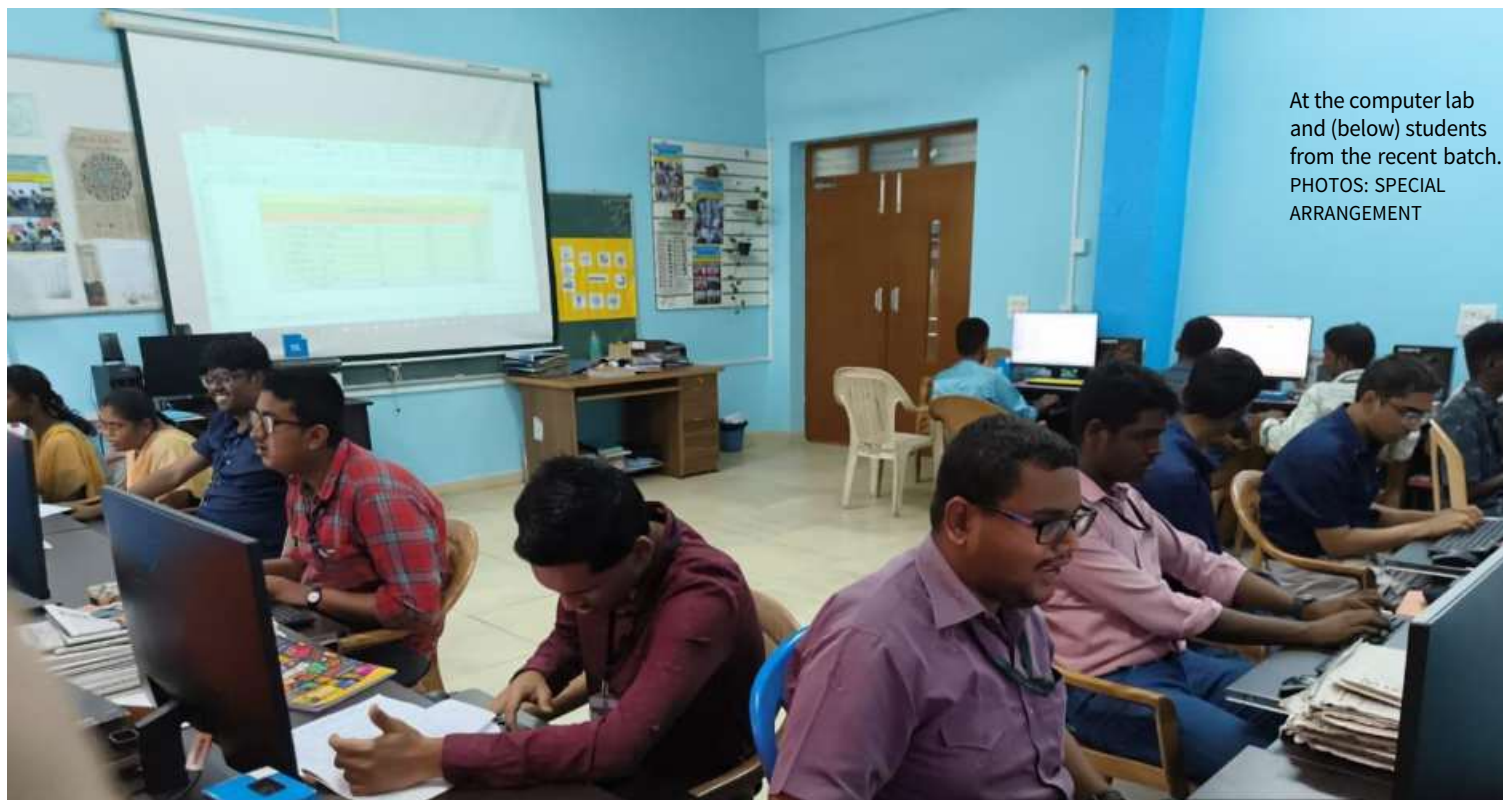
The main aim was to increase the oxygen supply and educate the future generation about the importance of nature and the need to protect it

V. KALAISELVI .

Kalaiselvi has been involved in several social service initiatives over the years, and she clubs this one among those marked by long-term social responsibility. Service of this kind does not bring immediate recognition, as the full extent of its impact is known only years later, and its benefits usually enjoyed only by following generations. “Duty is more important than recognition,” says Kalaiselvi, underlining her philosophy of meaningful service.

The once small saplings now provide shade, contribute to cleaner air, and continue to be proof of what sustained community efforts can achieve.

However, as the trees have grown larger over the years, a few branches have extended toward the power lines, raising a safety concern among residents. Hence the plea from Selvaraj to Greater Chennai Corporation to have the trees trimmed. Tree trimming is not just for people's safety, but for the trees' health as well: timely and scientific trimming can keep the trees from getting top-heavy. Therein lies an important lesson; planting trees is only the beginning of environmental stewardship. Preservation demands continual care, and the civic body's support in this area with its tree-trimming equipment cannot be replaced.



At the computer lab and (below) students from the recent batch.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Quick facts

Course: Diploma in Office Automation and Assistive Technology for PwD affiliated with Bharathidasan University

Minimum qualification: SSLC certificate

Who can join: Individuals with Intellectual Disabilities, Autism Spectrum Disorder, Mental Illness, Specific Learning Disabilities, and Multiple Disabilities

Content: Digital literacy, office automation, and exposure to assistive technologies.

Contact: 7667663877 / 7708018648 / 93829 34157

LIFFY THOMAS

They are diploma holders and it is a diploma like no other. It imparts training in office automation and assistive technology, but also seeks to put the students in command of their lives. The fifteen students who completed the one-year programme successfully also learnt how to socialise with peers, be independent, besides other social skills.

Diploma in Office Automation and Assistive Technology, as it is called, is offered by National Institute for Empowerment of Persons with Multiple Disabilities (NIEPMD) in Muttukadu. Affiliated with Bharathidasan University in Tiruchirappalli, the two-semester diploma programme is all set to have its fourth batch.

It is designed for those wired differently, blessed with different abilities. Among the 15 graduates, some have intellectual disabilities, some have multiple disabilities and a few are on the autism spectrum. Their abilities outshine their disabilities. At the farewell function held recently on the NIEPMD campus, no one was in any doubt about that. It was a moment to cherish for their parents and teachers.

There is a massive sense of achievement for parents of Suraag Sanjay K, and it comes from the fact that during the course of this diploma programme, he got used to travelling independently. For the first month, from his home in Ambattur to Muttukadu, Suraag, who has intellectual disability, and his father K.G. Sanjay would travel together. His father would drop him and wait at the campus till he finished classes in the evening. A gentle nudge from the faculty got the father-duo to effect a change in that routine. Today, Suraag travels on his own both ways; only on the

Equipped for office, empowered for life

The one-year diploma programme offered by NIEPMD in association with Bharathidasan University strikes a commendable balance between technical and soft skills



home stretch, the last mile, the father picks up the son.

Suraag's classmate Darshan, who has intellectual disability, started travelling by bus while pursuing Class XII. His father L. Gopi raised the bar during in the last one year making him travel by different bus routes. "For instance, during the Chennai Book Fair I dropped him one way and showed him the stop from where he could take his return journey. Another big change I saw in him is the ability to handle situations and also knowing what

to speak when," says Gopi, who works at a private firm.

Skills pertaining to financial literacy, communication and interpersonal dynamics got strengthened through structured group activities, helping the students engage more effectively with peers and instructors. The curriculum also reinforced punctuality, discipline and teamwork, say parents of the students. Besides a host of outdoor activities on the sprawling campus, a faculty from Tamil Nadu Dr. J. Jayalalitha Music and Fine Arts Un-

iversity visits the campus to offer music classes.

The computer lab for DOATT programme was set up with the sponsorship of Geetha Bhavan Trust which also developed a recreation lab for the students.

K. Balabaskar, Lecturer - Department of Adult Independent Learning, NIEPMD, says this inclusive, credit-based higher education programme is one of its kind in India.

"This is a college exclusive for those with special needs where we train them for a year in both techni-

cal know-how and essential life skills to equip them in all respects to take up higher studies or join the workplace," says Balabaskar.

Parents of children with disabilities spend a lot on therapy. "At NIEPMD, it is available within the campus along with a host of other facilities like psychomotor activity that they can avail," says Balabaskar, adding that B. Nithya Prabha, Lecturer and R. Rajesh Kanna, Clinical Assistant are also part of the team.

The one-month internship was another way to sensitise students to the demands of the workplace. Institutions such as Ragas Dental College, TamilNadu JJ. Fisheries University, Karna Vidya Foundation, Anna Centenary Library, MEPZ - Tambaram, Armoured Vehicles Nigam Limited in Avadi and even a neighbourhood stationery shop were on board offering internships to students with disabilities.

M. Prabavathy, associate professor, Centre for Differently Abled Persons, Bharathidasan University, says the University has been offering a number of courses for those with special needs since 2011 and NIEPMD requested them to extend this effort to benefit a large section of students.

Under this MoU, Bharathidasan University designs the course, conducts exams and rewards certificates. NIEPMD is the implementing partner. (Bachelor of computer application for speech and hearing impaired, photo editing and 2D animation course for autism are among courses the University offers).

Prabavathy says these are courses where the outcome is more important than considerations such as how many students are enrolled. "Special students need individualised attention as the learning needs are unique for each of them. These courses are aimed at making them independent, both financially and personally," says Prabavathy.

Course coordinators say that some have gone in for higher studies in regular colleges, some have joined the Job Coaching Scheme for TNPSC examination and many have joined the workplace.

Tiny arms stretch out for alms at swanky KNK Road

At the pedestrianised Khader Nawaz Khan Road in Nungambakkam, begging is rampant, and alms-seeking bowls are being carried not just by adults but children. How can you ensure government agencies put these children on the path to education and a better future?

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

Price tags inaccessible for a majority, Khader Nawaz Khan Road seemed designed solely for feet encased in a Miu Miu, a Polo Ralph Lauren and the like. That sentence is obviously hyperbole designed for effect. The point to be taken is the road is not just about high-street shopping experiences anymore. After pedestrianisation was walked into the picture, the price tags continued to smile only on select wallets, but the road began to sport a welcoming ear-to-ear grin for everyone. KNK Road has become a hangout for everyone, not just the haves with a capital H. Aesthetically designed wide walkways doused in decorative lighting impart to the space an Instagrammable appeal: and that automatically opens the floodgates of Gen Zs still in college who subsist on a measly pocket money and Insta-clicks.

Budget-friendly slip-on chappals are at ease striding down KNK Road. And feet

with visibly wornout footwear and with no footwear also traipse in; but these feet often go disturbingly with hands that are stretched out for alms. The contrast between opulence and dire need can be missed anywhere else in Chennai, but not at KNK Road.

Through the day, mendicants can be seen moving along this road, approaching those who can offer them RBI-blessed paper (Indian currency, that is). When someone capable of parting with a 'hallowed paper' or two is spotted, they are relentlessly followed, the beseeching tone kept persistent. On a few occasions, this reporter has noticed these mendicants declining food and insisting on cash. John Mathew, a regular at the KNK Road Pedestrian Plaza, observes: "Most of the mendicants refuse food despite incessant offers, instead insist on cash". Even GPay is good enough, Mathew adds with a chuckle, having GPaid a small sum once for a mendicant here. Another visitor

notes that they throw away any food given to them, suggesting the preference for cash over food is a well-entrenched attitude among these mendicants.

Speaking from her experience, Joanne .N says they shadow their "target", refusing to take no for an answer; they are dogged in the pursuit of people they assume would part with some cash, following them for long distances. "It can get intimidating," adds Joanne.

Children with begging bowls

Mendicants have as much right to the pedestrianised space at KNK Road as anybody else. But what is disturbing is the shoe size of some of those feet. Small children frequently accompany the adults seeking alms and seek alms alongside those adults. Under the scorching sun, they walk on crowded pavements, extending their tiny hands toward strangers, seeking money. Their presence transforms what might initially be dismissed as a public inconvenience into a serious social concern that requires thought and intervention.

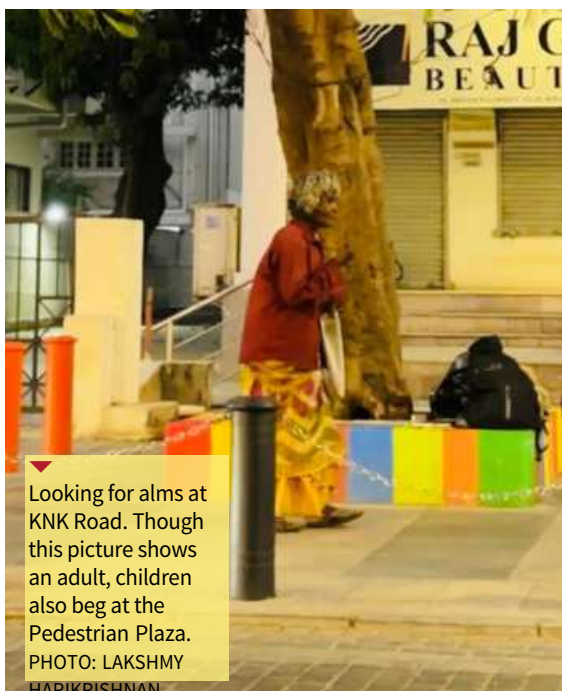
The issue of begging is neither new nor simple. It has existed forever, fostered by migration, poverty, lack of opportunities and sys-

temic socio-economic fault lines. There is also a psychological side to begging: deadbeats, people who have given up the fight, stopped trying to work for their sustenance. However, what is common should not be equated with what is normal. Repeated occurrences should not normalise a problem, making society immune to it. There are systems in place to address this particular problem, systems that could be ineffectual and flabby for want of regular exercise. Rather than extending some succour to the outstretched arms, those systems should be challenged to offer the lasting solutions they promise. Effort should be taken to find out what could be keeping these children on the streets seeking alms. Children belong in schools, not on streets, earning their daily bread with a begging bowl.

Help should be sought. That begs the question: where?

Call child helpline 1098.

Call Chennai District Child Protection Unit -- North at 6369124017; Chennai District Child Protection Unit -- South is located in Alandur; and Chennai District Child Protection Unit -- Central in T. Nagar. There is also support for begging adults, offered by a network of NGOs and government agencies.



Looking for alms at KNK Road. Though this picture shows an adult, children also beg at the Pedestrian Plaza. PHOTO: LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

TANKER Foundation founder trustee meets Dalai Lama



Amid many cases of kidney disease and kidney failure among underprivileged communities in McLeod Gunj and surrounding regions, Georgi Abraham, Founder Trustee of TANKER Foundation, met Tibetan spiritual leader and Nobel Peace Laureate Dalai Lama on May 23, 2026.

According to a press release, the conversation focused on the work carried out by TANKER foundation in providing free dialysis treatment, conducting awareness programmes and screening camps for early detection and prevention, and supporting research related to renal health. During the interaction, Dr Abraham said that TANKER foundation would extend support in establishing a dialysis centre in the region which aims to provide free and subsidised dialysis treatment for patients.

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Lychee time in Kilpauk



▼ A vendor selling lychees in Kilpauk. PHOTO: PRABHU M

Entrepreneurial skill training in solar energy

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute is conducting a training programme on entrepreneurial skills necessary in the solar energy sector. It will be held from June 3 to 12. According to a press release, the programme will focus on basics of solar energy, solar components and system design. The session will also cover concepts of marketing, pricing, and legal procedures.

The institute is also conducting another workshop on baking from June 2 to 5. According to a press release, the session will focus of making baked products from millets, heirloom rice varieties, and wheat. This includes: cakes, breads, biscuits, cookies, and pizzas. Participants will also learn about packing, labelling and pricing of the products.

Prior registration is necessary to take part in the sessions. Those from 18



Photo used for representational purpose only.

to 55 years of age with a minimum educational qualification of class 10 can apply. Hostel facility is available. The workshops will be held at the institute's

premises at EDII Office Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate, Guindy.

For details, call 8668102600 / 78069 18309.

Workshop on making incense sticks



Photo used for representational purpose only. THE HINDU

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a culinary workshop on making flavour powders from spices on June 4. According to a press release, the session will focus on powders meant for vegetarian and non-vegetarian cuisines.

Another workshop on making incense sticks and camphors will be held on June 5. Both the sessions will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For registration details, call 044 - 29530048

Bakrid celebrated at school ground in Perambur



A congregational prayer was held on May 28 at Don Bosco School ground at Sembium in Perambur as part of Eid Al Adha (Bakrid) celebration. The event witnessed a huge gathering of people.

Toastmasters club to meet today

Perambur Speakers Toastmasters Club, a unit of Toastmasters International, will be holding its meeting on May 31 at Lane Consultancy, Second Floor, Perambur. Time: At 5.30 p.m.

According to a press release, club members will deliver prepared speeches and participate in impromptu speaking sessions. The theme for this session is "Sustainable Journeys, Timeless Memories." The programme is open to all and no fee will be charged to attend the session, adds the release.

For details, call 9846735967

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